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Recognition of Prior Learning

Is our performance test of English a good fit for the purpose?

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ABSTRACT

Living in learning societies has brought an increased focus to lifelong learning and educational policies that support it. One such policy is recognition of prior learning (RPL). In Finnish higher education, the most popular procedure for RPL is a test. This raises the question of how well this assessment method serves its purpose. To examine this theoretically, we used Andersson's 2006 template. Empirically, we gathered anonymous data on the type and range of prior learning among 273 students from engineering and industrial design seeking RPL of English, and analyzed the data in Excel using raw numbers. This analysis shows that the tasks in our RPL test of English differs considerably from those reported in our survey of RPL seekers. This mismatch indicates that we should either adopt an open, divergent assessment method, such as a portfolio, or change our undergraduate English curricula for both engineering and industrial design to better align them with the working-life communication tasks identified in this study – if a closed, convergent assessment method (such as a test) is preferred. Either way, the change would provide better support for RPL and for development action at our university related to strengthening academic-industry relations.

Conference Key Areas: Engineering education research, Curriculum development, Continuing Engineering Education and Lifelong Learning

Keywords: engineering education, university practices, curriculum development, learning assessment

INTRODUCTION

To support internationalization linked to the European Higher Education Area (EHEA), a recent development in higher education institutions (HEIs) in Finland includes

implementing procedures that support *recognition of prior learning* (RPL)[1] [1], [2]. An aim of the international strategy for HEIs in Finland has been to create comparable and compatible systems in Europe for higher education. A related measure includes HEIs implementing practices of accreditation and recognition of prior learning that are consistent for students [3], [2], [4]. Not only are policies being implemented but also much of the RPL research at Finnish HEIs tends to address policy, administration, or quality issues, e.g. [5], [6], [7], [8]. Other research in Finland also suggests that the administrative stance towards RPL assessment limits recognition to formal learning, e.g. [9], [10 pp. 20-30]. Similarly, benchmarking at 12 Finnish Language Centres reveals the most common practice for RPL of English to be exemption tests linked to formal learning [11 p.13].

In the present study, the exemption exam is a performance test, covering oral and/or literary skills. The test includes tasks, such as writing an email, giving a presentation and answering related follow-up questions. The selected assessment was easy to implement, as exemption tests for the two skill areas were already an option for students[2]. In the modified version for assessing RPL of English, the aim is for candidates to demonstrate their acquired professional English competence that is comparable to that achieved in the undergraduate English course (for which they are seeking recognition).

Over time, however, the English teachers at the Aalto University Language Centre began to question whether the RPL of English performance test is adequate for the intended purpose or whether an alternative procedure, such as a portfolio, would better capture RPL of English (for students of engineering and industrial design). This question arose as some of the RPL seekers who failed the task-based, performance test complained that test was not representative of their prior learning of English at work (i.e. non-formal learning). To investigate this problem from a theoretical perspective, we analyze our performance test using Andersson's template on the faces of RPL [12 p. 47]. From an empirical perspective, we analyze the task type and range of prior non-formal and informal learning (of English) among engineering and industrial design students seeking RPL of English. These analyses serve as tools to inform the content validity of an assessment for RPL of English for students of engineering and industrial design.

1 SOME RPL ASSESSMENT CONSIDERATIONS

For RPL, different procedures are required for the three learning paths: formal, non-formal, and informal. In the case of formal studies, a common procedure is to request a transfer of credits from one institution to another. This procedure entails submitting evidence, such as transcripts, course descriptions, and other relevant documentation[3]. Thus, this learning path creates fewer challenges for RPL than the non-formal and informal paths, where there may be no official documentation showing a qualification or certification. The RPL procedure for accrediting the latter two paths is the focus of the present study since these paths require a demonstration of previously acquired competences. This demonstration can include passing an exam, submitting a portfolio,

[1] Although the Council of Europe (Recommendation 2012/C 398/01) uses the term *validation of prior learning*, we adopt the term *recognition of prior learning* as it is used in the English-language documents published by the Finnish Ministry of Education and Culture.

[2] The existing exams were first given in 2004, and originally designed for a different purpose (i.e. targeting bilinguals, international baccalaureate, and native speakers). In 2011, they were modified to fulfill the new intended purpose (i.e. RPL of English). The main modification was to emphasize professional English in the tasks and criteria.

[3] For details on the European credit transfer system, see European Commission 2015

partaking in an interview, or participating in some other established procedure as defined by the target department or institution[4]. Furthermore, the type of RPL in the present study is known as *credentialism* since it involves an exchange value: candidates can receive credits upon successful demonstration of their prior learning. In short, it is a venue for gaining credit for a specific course given at a particular institution, a result that is determined by the RPL assessment.

For assessing non-formal and informal RPL, what knowledge can count as valid is not straightforward. For example, some scholars perceive RPL assessment as a venue for widening what disciplinary knowledge can count as valid, e.g. [13], [14]. This discussion covers different angles, including views that see RPL as a way to integrate knowledge holistically [15] as well as to engage heterogeneous knowledge rather than concentrate on academic ones [16]. Another scholar also argues that RPL involves interrelated knowledge on three levels: mainstream curricula, RPL curricula, and prior learning considerations. She contends that such a view enhances the epistemological accountability of RPL practices [13]. As these examples illustrate, much of the theoretical positioning for RPL questions what knowledge to count as valid in an RPL assessment.

Although assessing RPL is a complex issue, Andersson [12] sheds some light on it in his discussion, which culminates in what he calls the two faces of RPL. Based on this idea, he presents a template for practical use that helps to interpret the faces of an RPL assessment practice. In the template shown in Table 2, there are eight aspects to RPL outlined in the left-hand column. In the center are the two faces with their different foci. To develop understanding of our RPL of English test, we will use this template as a heuristic device. The right-hand column shows which foci describe the RPL of English performance test in the present study.

Table 1 Analysis of our RPL of English test using Andersson's template in [12 p. 47].

Aspects of RPL	**Difference in focus**		**RPL of English**
	Face 1	***Face 2***	**Analysis**
Relation to the system	*RPL adapted to the existing system*	*RPL changing the system*	***Face 1***
Close/open	*Convergent*	*Divergent*	***Face 1***
Foundation of trust	*Reliability*	*Validity*	***Face 1 & 2***
Focus of measurement	*Commensurability*	*Particularity*	***Face 1***
Horizon of meaning	*Universal/global*	*Local*	***Face 1***
Constitution of knowledge	*Atomism*	*Holism*	***Face 1***
Orientation	*Competence*	*Potential*	***Face 1***
Functions	*Selection Summative, predictive*	*Transformation Formative*	***Face 1***

What the analysis shows is that our RPL of English test aligns primarily with the foci of Face 1. Given that we adopted a modified version of an existing exam, it is not surprising to find that our RPL of English test is convergent. This approach supports

[4] For an example of RPL in Finnish HEIs, see in Finnish http://tunnistaosaaminen.fi/node/20

confining RPL knowledge to that defined by a closed system. Because our assessment methods require producing language, the measurement of language competence involves individual responses that contain different content and thus require rating scales. Although this type of assessment is generally higher in validity than in reliability, it may be that this 'reliable' approach excludes valid content in RPL assessment. Moreover, assessing with rating scales generally suggests a holistic approach. However, we would describe our rating scales as atomistic since they focus on discrete points relevant to course content (not to holistic learning as is the case in RPL). In short, the scales provide a comparison between two test-taker responses on a limited range of features that do not provide the depth of knowledge that a holistic approach might reveal. This type of assessment, nevertheless, increases reliability and commensurability. From the template, we also see that the function of the RPL of English test is summative. The grade reported (at the end) indicates whether an RPL of English seeker has succeeded. A pass mark suggests that the candidate is likely to pass a final exam in an undergraduate English course. Although this method of RPL assessment, i.e. a test, is common practice in Finnish universities, it is unclear whether the approach is a good fit for the purpose. At least, the data in the present study suggest that this closed approach may be marginalizing RPL.

Using Andersson's template clarifies the faces of our RPL of English test. It also raises the question of whether our RPL of English test is a good fit for the purpose. To what extent does an approach that controls 'valid' knowledge in a prejudiced way serve our RPL seekers? Is it possible that their prior experiences could contribute to defining valid knowledge in our RPL of English test and simultaneously inform our curricula on real-world communicative competences in academic-industry relations? This kind of information could help to inform the English curricula as well as support development actions at our university, which include both preparing students for working life and strengthening skills for lifelong learning.

2 METHODS AND RESULTS

To investigate the research question, members of the testing team distributed a questionnaire on the type and range of prior non-formal and informal learning among 379 students participating in the RPL of English oral performance test. The responses were anonymous and the response rate for the questionnaire was 273 or 72%. The purposive sample included students from engineering and industrial design, who wanted to demonstrate their prior knowledge of English.

The questionnaire consisted of 15 items. Of those, 12 were multiple choice with an open option and three were open-ended. The main themes included context of usage, frequency of English use, task types and work experience. From the multiple-choice alternatives, students could select more than one option. The categorical data were analyzed using a data spreadsheet to count raw numbers, and the results are presented in charts.

Regarding student background, the results show that about two thirds were aiming at a bachelor's and one third a master's degree. This spread can be expected since most students complete their compulsory foreign language studies at the bachelor's level and those who have not then complete it at the master's level. Because the respondents are attempting RPL of English, it is assumed that they need to meet an obligatory foreign language requirement.

An examination of the types of prior non-formal and informal learning of English, the responses to Q3 reveal a wide range. In Fig. 1, the types of prior learning indicate that

about two thirds worked in English, roughly half engaged in self-study, and approximately one quarter used English in leisure activities. The findings also indicate a range of activities not related to academic or professional English, but which may have an impact on general proficiency. These items include the following: English courses at school, living/studying abroad, and being an English native-speaker or having an English native-speaking parent. What these responses suggest is a focus on nativelikeness as the measure of success as opposed to academic and professional communication skills. This fallacy explain one reason why some students attempt RPL. In other words, they have misconceptions about what they need to demonstrate in RPL of English. Even native speakers are not born with academic and professional English.

Another interesting point in Fig. 1 is the context of learning, particularly those supporting professional English via academic-industry relations. These contexts include using English in student exchange programs, International Baccalaureate (IB) degrees, English-native-language (ENL) universities, and English-medium instruction (EMI) at university. Although these contexts pertain to a small number of respondents, they point to venues for acquiring academic and professional English related to the respondents' fields of study. This prior learning provides evidence of non-formal learning that supports developing knowledge within the field of study, where developing communication skills in English may be a by-product.

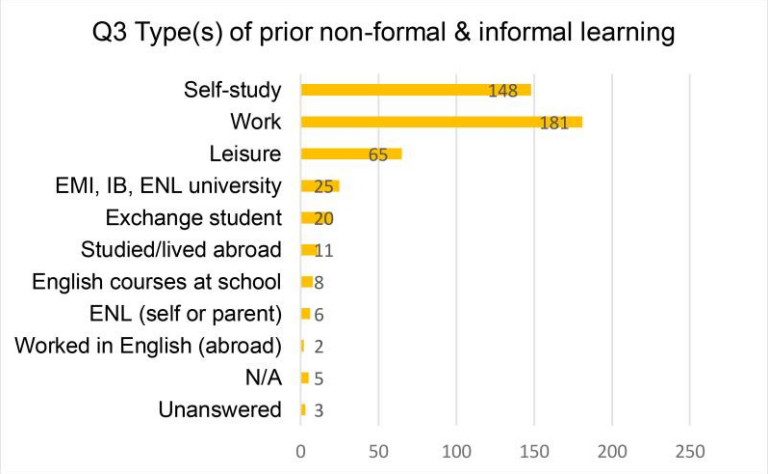


Figure 1 Types of prior non-formal and informal learning (responses in raw numbers).

In Fig. 2, the responses on RPL workplace roles indicate that many students acquired English through professional training. For example, roughly one third (95 of 273) used English as project workers and as interns (86 of 273), ten percent both as project leaders (27 of 273) and as apprentices (29 of 273), and a small number in a range of other types of professional training, such as doing research, teaching as an assistant, working in customer service. However, some of the roles reported also include roles unrelated to the field of engineering or industrial design. It is questionable whether these are relevant to RPL of English for engineering. In addition, roughly twenty percent (57 of 273) responded

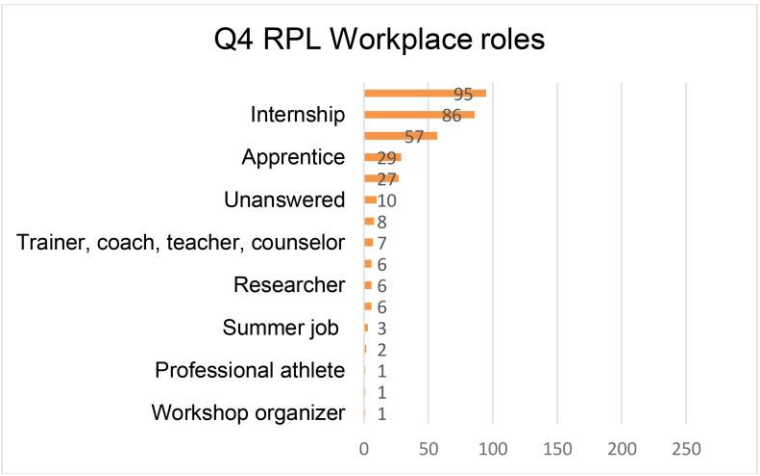


Figure 2 A variety of workplace roles (in raw numbers) reported by RPL seekers.

that workplace roles were inapplicable. From this response, we do not know whether the respondents had no workplace roles or no work experience.

Findings on the task types reported for English at work (Q5) are presented in Fig. 3. What this chart shows is that tasks in spoken English are central to the prior work-related experiences, with small talk being the most frequently reported task. Nearly half of the respondents reported having engaged in small talk as a work-related task. The next most frequently reported tasks include participating in projects and meetings, each roughly 45%. Following this is partaking in phone/video calls and giving presentations, each nearly 40%. On other tasks, there were very few responses. This observation includes writing tasks in English, where roughly 10% reported needing to write emails and documentation. In addition, similar to Q4, roughly 20% reported work-related tasks as inapplicable. This finding seems to suggest that the respondents have no prior work-related experience in English.

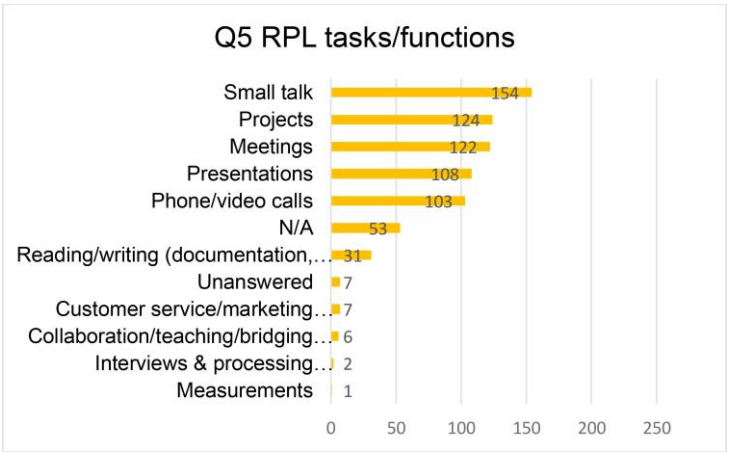


Figure 3 RPL seekers reported a variety of workplace roles.

To gain understanding of the professional context of prior learning of English, we investigated the skill areas in which the tasks were performed. Fig. 4 indicates the most common professional areas to include studies (nearly 50%), engineering (nearly 50%), and doing business (26%). These findings are not surprising given that many of the respondents have completed a study exchange or internship and that some are also doing their engineering studies through English-medium instruction.

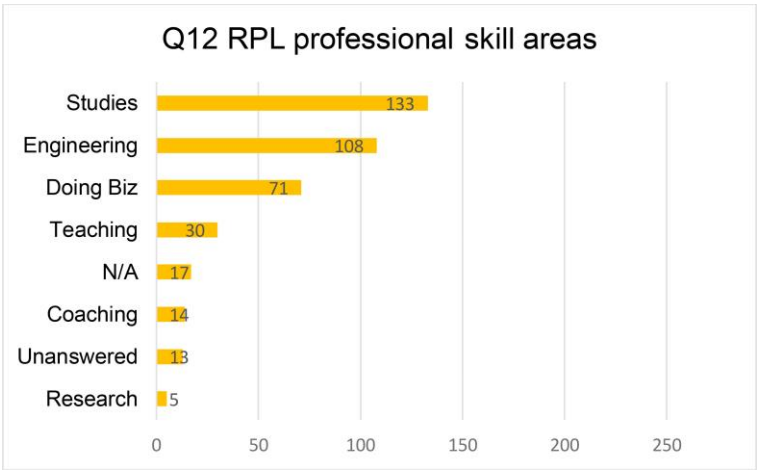


Figure 4 Professional skill areas reported by RPL seekers.

Not only did we investigate the task types and range but also the international context of English usage. As Fig. 5 and 6 show, the prior learning of English primarily occurred with other non-native speakers of English in international contexts outside the English native-speaking world. In Fig. 5, the findings show that nearly half operated in English with other non-natives of English, and almost 40% used English equally with native and non-natives. This finding suggests that English is the language of choice for communicating in English as a lingua franca (ELF). The responses in Fig. 6 also support the primary use as ELF, with Europe being the main hub of prior learning of

English. Overall, the data indicate that using English with native speakers only is uncommon. As shown in Fig. 5, less than 10% reported using English with only native speakers, which suggests that their prior learning of English took place in an English-speaking country in a non-international context with only locals. Moreover, roughly 20% (i.e. 55 of 273) reported the location of prior learning of English as inapplicable. We do not know why, but perhaps it is related to communicating via technology, such as Skype, NetMeeting, or other social networking tools, where interaction occurs in a space not defined by a single location. In addition, those who reported no interaction in English may have participated in self-study, a form of prior learning that could involve using English (e.g. reading, playing computer games, and so on) without social interaction.

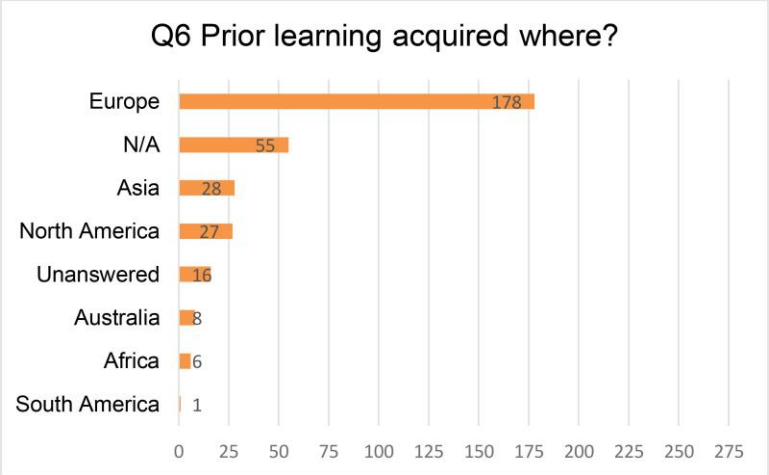


Figure 5 The continents on which prior learning of English occurred.

All in all the spreadsheet analysis provides some general information about the data. It shows the versatility of the prior learning of English among engineering and industrial design students. These prior experiences could also be relevant to learning professional English for the field-specific area.

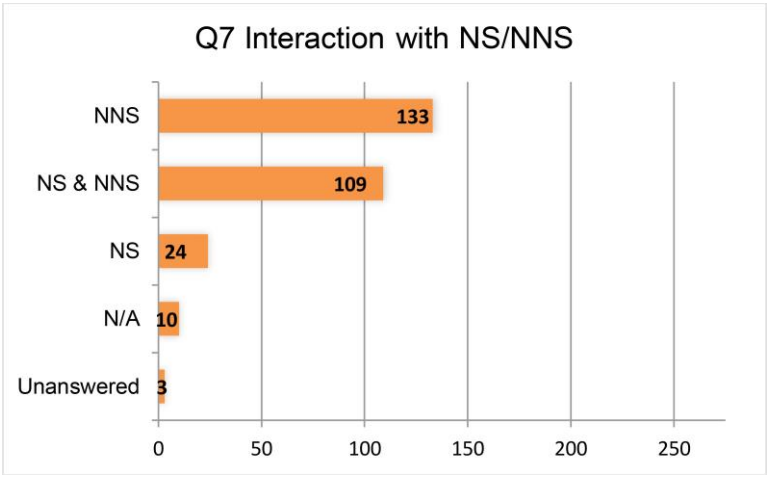


Figure 6 Interaction with English native (NS) and non-native speakers (NNS).

3 DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSIONS

This study investigated whether our RPL of English test for engineering and industrial design students is a good fit for the purpose. Theoretically, it analysed the RPL of English performance test using Andersson's template in [12 p.47]. The findings show that our RPL of English test is a closed, convergent approach to RPL assessment. A primary goal of this type of assessment is to control knowledge in a biased way. In other words, academics decide what knowledge is valid in university curricula. However, the present study indicates that such an approach can exclude relevant RPL curricula, thereby marginalizing RPL.

Empirically, the study investigated RPL seekers' prior learning of English through a survey. The findings show versatility with the task type and range for prior learning of English. This observation suggests that our performance test with set pre-defined tasks (e.g. writing an email and giving a presentation) is too limited to serve the purpose. While the performance test adequately covers tasks from an undergraduate English

course, it omits many tasks important to working-life skills reported in the present study (e.g. phone/video calls, small talk, and meetings). Our findings indicate that an analysis of RPL seekers' prior learning is one way to inform not only the academic curricula but also the RPL assessment practice, given a divergent approach.

Although exams may be preferred, it does not mean that this assessment practice is a good fit for RPL. For example, a recent small-scale study at a university in Finland (N=21) found that students preferred an RPL exemption exam to other assessment methods [17 p. 121]. This finding seems surprising given the myriad of prior learning of English reported by the RPL seekers, both in that study and in the present one. While the reasons for this preference are unclear, a familiar assessment option may be viewed as 'safe' over a less familiar one that requires gathering evidence and a comprehensive reflection of prior learning [18 p. 72]. Although preferred, an RPL exam limits what can be assessed and fails to include authentic assessment, a test facet considered important in language assessment.

From the point of view of serving (authentic) RPL seekers and supporting prior learning, a key question is what changes might improve our current RPL assessment practice? As the present findings suggest, performance testing may not be an adequate choice for covering the domains of non-formal and informal learning, which encompass a diversity of learning tasks, contexts and processes. For example, the contextual and tacit nature of the learning that occurs in these domains complicates the validity of an assessment constructed to cover a narrow sliver of content. Not only are tests narrowly focused, they are also teacher-centered. For instance, it is the teacher who decides both the content and the tasks to be assessed. The teacher is also the sole assessor of the test-taker's performance. This situation raises the question of whether testing can be properly constructed to measure out-of-classroom learning where the task type and range is much broader and richer than those taught in a course. In other words, the current teacher-centered method of assessing RPL of English appears to be inadequate for assessing learner-centered learning. This observation also implies that our current RPL practice falls short of goals supporting European educational policies regarding recognition of prior non-formal and informal learning.

The pedagogical implications of the present study suggest that a more divergent assessment practice would be a better fit for the purpose. Ideally, the RPL assessment practice would be more learner-centered, address authentic learner needs, and provide a means to document a comprehensive collection of learning achieved in non-credited, non-credentialed contexts. For this purpose, portfolio assessment is especially useful. This assessment method is designed to support learning and to capture its connections to instructional objectives. These features are relevant to assessing prior non-formal and informal learning. A portfolio assessment would also support learners trying to attain educational qualifications while learning in out-of-classroom contexts.

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